

DILIP BANERJEE



THE FIGHT CLUB

Inter-service rivalry just moved to a new turf—the plush lawns and manicured hedges of the elite century-old Delhi Gymkhana Club. When General J.J. Singh, chief of army staff stands for election for the president of the club on September 29, his rival will be Indian Air Forces's (IAF) Western Air Commander Air Marshal Padamjit Singh Ahluwalia. The talk in the club's cavernous ballroom has moved on from cocktails and *shammi kebabs* to this clash of the titans. It is the first time a serving army chief has thrown his hat in the ring against another brass hat, even if it is a mere technicality—General Singh retires a day after the election.

Clearly, this is no ordinary election as this is no ordinary club. Sprawled across 27 acres on the posh Safdarjung Road, it is India's most politically influential club, not only because it adjoins the prime minister's official Race Course Road residence but because its corridors—designed by Edwin Lutyens—host the Capital's power list including the Gandhis, cabinet ministers, bureaucrats, business tycoons and, of course, the armed forces. It takes 30 years to get the club's membership.

POLLS APART: General Singh (R) and Air Marshal Ahluwalia

The presidential election of the Capital's elite club takes a potentially embarrassing turn, pitting the army chief against IAF's western air commander



Who will replace the outgoing president, former RAW chief A.S. Dulat, who steps down this month, has fast become an inter-service tussle. A victory for General Singh will make him the first army chief to head the prestigious club. A defeat will prove to be a severe embarrassment not only for the services which are striving for jointmanship but also for Singh who as the senior-most service chief also wears the hat of chairman, Chief of Staffs Committee.

Hence, attempts are on to avert a clash with Air Chief Marshal F.H. Major being called in to persuade Ahluwalia to withdraw. But, the flamboyant fighter pilot, who heads the IAF's largest air command, is unmoved so far. "The issue is not of rank but who is more suitable to run the club of which I have been a member for over 25 years and have been on the managing committee of the club for the past one year," says Ahluwalia.

The lines have already been drawn for the impending air-land battle and campaigning has begun with a series of parties lined up over the next few days to drum up support. Friends are being called and their support sought.

Though the club has 5,500 active permanent members, the verdict will rest with the 1,300 members who reside in Delhi and are hence eligible to vote. Unwritten club rules say the post of president should rotate between a civilian and a retired officer of the armed forces. IAF says it has not held the president's post since Air Chief Marshal Katre became president 23 years ago while at least three generals and three admirals have occupied the position during this period.

As army members clearly outnumber the other two services, giving Singh a distinct advantage, it is the civilian vote which will decide the outcome. Elections are a recent phenomena for the club. Earlier, senior government servants used to be invited to head the club, a convention that changed in the early '80s. The last big fight took place in 2005 when Dulat defeated civil aviation secretary Ajay Prasad. The stage is now set for another battle royale. **by Sandeep Unnithan**